"Flattery Instead of Representation:" Sterling A. Brown's Frustrations with Black Drama

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In 1937 Sterling A. Brown published *Negro Poetry and Drama*, his important critical study of Black characters in the theatre. His book includes critiques of plays written, directed, and acted out by Black artists, as well as notes on Black audiences. Brown uses his knowledge as a theatre critic to analyze why Black drama has not been as successful as drama by white authors and actors, claiming there are many technical shortcomings in the industry. Brown boldly states that "none of the Negro folk playwrights show the structural skill of white dramatists," perhaps reflecting biases of the time (Brown 122). However, the book also covers the evolution of Black characters in drama from the audience's perspective. Brown acknowledges that Black presence in drama has been a slow-growing phenomenon because of internalized expectations from white audiences, which prevented the implementation of non-stereotypical Black representation: "The negro audience frequently wants flattery instead of representation, plaster saints instead of human beings, drawing rooms instead of the homes of the people. And the typical white audience wants stereotypes" (Brown 123). While he notes deficiencies in Black playwriting throughout his book and suggests that the industry should foster new and young theatrical leadership, Brown criticizes the technical deficiencies in Black playwriting and the limiting expectations of audiences. Rather, he argues that it was these audience expectations that caused the continuation of "the Negro's [...] rigidly circumscribed" role in drama (Brown 1).

Throughout his career, and before the publication of *Negro Poetry and Drama*, Brown thought about the Black character as seen by white audiences. In April of 1933, an article entitled "Negro Character As Seen by White Authors" in the *Journal of Negro Education* wherein he describes the types of Black characters displayed in theater written by white playwrights. The objective of the article, he states, is to highlight that "the majority of books about Negroes merely stereotype Negro character. It is the purpose of this paper to point out the prevalence and history of these stereotypes" (Brown 56). Here, the difference between Brown's analysis of Black characters in theater from 1933 and 1937 is the author and the audience. In analyzing the two side-by-side, two similarities become apparent: in playwriting by white authors and Black authors, "all of these stereotypes are marked either by exaggeration or omissions; that they all agree in stressing the Negro's divergence from an Anglo-Saxon norm to the flattery of the latter" (Brown 56). The temporal difference between Brown's book, *Poetry and Drama*, and his essay about portraying Black characters testifies to the long-standing norm of characterizing Black characters. Thus, even during the evolution of theater, Brown's writing, his influence and advocacy, and writing and playwriting faced seemingly immovable barriers when it came to producing profitable theater due to the lack of willingness to respectfully and accurately represent Black characters and folk-life.

While *Negro Poetry and Drama* demonstrates Brown's cumulative opinion that predominantly white, misinformed audiences are limiters of authentic Black writing, archival evidence suggests that Brown continued to think and write about this subject after the book's publication. In my recent sessions in the Sterling A. Brown archives at Williams College, I discovered an unpublished, typed, and annotated manuscript, "Drama," in which Brown discusses the shortcomings of Black representation in the dramatic arts, crediting it to the failure of Black artists to capitalize on "the mine of folk humor which is the Negro's birthright"; the manuscript signals a shift from a dual focus on audience and playwright to a greater emphasis on playwright shortcomings (Brown 10). I was intrigued by Brown's bold statements of criticism toward the quality of Black writing and thus was inspired to uncover more of his thinking on the subject. My search brought me to his book, *Negro Poetry and Drama*. The book seemed to contain expanded versions of the ideas I saw in his manuscript, which led me to believe that "Drama" was written first. However, upon further examination, I was surprised to notice that the manuscript's final section describes drama from 1917 to 1941, which he defines as the "Modern Era," indicating that Brown must have written "Drama" after his book's publication. I was particularly fascinated by the fact that this unpublished

manuscript condensed his thoughts on drama without recognizing the role of the audience. As in his book, "Drama" focuses on the intersection between drama and social justice. For example, Brown notes that "from the very beginning the American theatre relegated to him [Black characters] the role of clown, and the most recent cinema seeks to perpetuate that tradition", emphasizing the impact societal norms had on Black characters (Brown 1). However, he also highlights rising Black playwrights or actors, noting that Little Theatres "have contributed to a certain drama-consciousness among Negros" (Brown 12). Because this work takes the form of a fourteen-page typed manuscript, there is significantly less space to elaborate on the role of the audience. Instead of focusing on how white audiences greatly influenced the persistent misrepresentation and stereotyping of Black characters in theatre, as in *Negro Poetry and Drama*, Brown chose to focus on the inferior storytelling abilities of Black playwriting. Brown's condensed iteration, thinking, and choice of what to include suggest that this manuscript may have had a different goal than the book. These two documents share a similar objective: To encourage increases in Black representation in drama and accurately portray Black folk life; yet, they differ in delivery style and sense of urgency. My initial analysis of "Drama" indicated that it was an undeveloped predecessor to his book. However, my discovery that his manuscript came after his book's publication altered my assumptions, suggesting that Brown shifted his intentions rather than his ideas. While it may occur to one that the manuscript could have been compiled or composed in stages, it is evident from in-person examination and a staple in the pages that Brown likely typed his manuscript in closely-timed sittings. Examining his archival material plays a crucial role in deciphering his thoughts on what was necessary to inspire and elevate the Black artistic community. Thus, the comparison between his published and unpublished work gives insight into the social state of theatre and proves his continued dedication to advancing the field of Black drama.

In "Drama," Brown describes the history of Black people in theatrical productions to emphasize the enduring patterns of mistreatment toward Black people in drama. Before the manuscript begins its sectioned analysis, Brown notes the generally underdeveloped skill of Black writers and the failure to break from the frequent use of stereotypes and harmful imagery of Black people in drama. His generalization is further reinforced in his written chronology by selected periods, which Brown groups as the following: "Beginnings," "Middle Period," and "Modern Era," the first of which begins in 1776. Each section emphasizes a new evolution in Black stereotyping. Throughout "Drama," Brown gives specific examples where Black playwrights lack the skills to write compelling plots and character dynamics. He notes that in Black drama, although "the work is historically important; as drama, it is extremely weak" (Brown 5). For instance, he includes a critique of William Wells Brown's play, *The Escape, or a Leap for Freedom*, written in 1858, where he notes that the main melodramatic, love-affair-driven plot was "utterly impossible from the theatre angle" (Brown 5). Despite being a technically flawed play, its message emphasizes how "universally accepted [the Black comic] stereotype had become by 1858" (Brown 4). While the playwright's message is important, Brown claims it is undercut by poor skill and bad delivery. Yes, William Wells Brown was "an important anti-slavery writer and lecturer, the author of the first American Negro novel, [and] was also the race's first dramatist," Sterling Brown admits, but in 1858, he was catering to a primarily white audience who commonly degraded and oppressed Black people in the arts and life.

As in Negro Poetry and Drama, Brown traces the arc of Black theatre companies after 1865 in his unpublished manuscript. However, Brown continues to attribute the failure of theatrical companies to internal deficiencies in the technical abilities and narrative quality in Black playwriting rather than disclosing that audiences fundamentally rejected their work as he does in his book. During the "Middle Period" section of "Drama," Brown notes that while collegiate-level drama companies were essential for the development of Black writers and their growing numbers, "many have been shortlived [and have] failed probably because of lack of trained leadership. [...] It tended to become a social rather than a serious artistic movement" (Brown 12). Here, he places significant responsibility for the failure of these companies on leadership and writership rather than on the audience, noting that writers were too focused on the message of their work rather than its artistic quality. It is important to note that Brown mentions an increase in Black theatrical spaces and an increased development of the "Negro show." These Black companies began to break the minstrel tradition around 1890, displaying "syncopated Negro music" and musical comedies. However, despite the important contributions of Black playwrights to American theatre and the increase in Black artists and theatre companies in serious dramatic areas, Brown describes them as "not well-organized or outstanding enough to make an impression upon the chroniclers" (Brown 6). Black playwrights and actors attempted to break free of stereotypes heavily present in theatre but were rejected by larger audiences and never took off. Instead of noting that audiences on Broadway at the time were looking for mass appeal rather than artistic and social statements, Brown blames the minimal presence of Black people in serious drama on effort: "The Negro was

on his part to write it" (Brown 7). Through critiques of various efforts to foreground educational messages, Brown claims that the authors "apparently knew nothing of the theatre," reinforcing his general blame of misrepresentation on skill (Brown 7). Negro Poetry and Drama highlights similar points, however, with the acknowledgment of the audience's role. He draws attention to the internalized expectations of the audience when watching drama produced by Black playwrights: "The audience was readier to sympathize with heroes and heroines nearer to themselves in appearance" (Brown 113). Already, by virtue of a difference in race, social status, and the current stage of development in drama at the time, audiences were set up not to regard the "Negro show" as serious drama. Furthermore, he notes that because Black playwrights were respected less than their white counterparts, it was necessary to use the little theatres as laboratories for the Black dramatists to aid in their gaining respect in the theatrical industry. Brown uses more subtle uplift to stimulate the improvement of Black playwrights, conscious of the fact that the life of a Black dramatist is made more difficult by their position in society: "The necessary apprenticeships of the playwright in the theatre, beyond the footlights, is still too rare, and college dramatics cannot sufficiently offset this" (Brown 123). However, he confesses that this is no excuse not to be assiduous. Ultimately, Brown's condensed message in "Drama" from his more holistic message in Negro Poetry and Drama indicates the continued unfortunate state of Black representation in the dramatic industry. While in 1937, the theatre was dominated by discriminatory practices, which persisted through 1941 in Brown's timeline. The stagnancy of the industry prompted Brown to continue his literature on the subject more forcibly. Brown's praise of Black playwright's attempts at significant theatre and his awareness of the difficulty for Black artists to get their foot in the door in Negro Poetry and Drama are offset by his criticisms in "Drama." His abridging of an integrated, encouraging message in his book only allows space for an intensified message that the Black playwright must make space for himself in the field of drama, rather than waiting for an audience to readily accept a broadened industry.

Brown's eagerness to foreground Black playwrights and encourage their improvement highlights his commitment as a teacher. In 1973, the Library of Congress recorded Brown performing a selection of poems. During the recording, Brown frequently pauses between poems, drinking water, or beckoning for his wife, and sometimes, stopping to chat with the technicians for up to a few minutes. It is not until about halfway through the session that Brown clarifies why he must take these breaks. He comments that his poetry readings are exhausting because he regards them as a performance: "Now, I'm gonna stop after each one, but not too long, you know, it uses me up. I'm kind of acting them out" (30:12). By admitting that these readings take a substantial amount of energy to produce, he demonstrates a level of effort that is unique to most artists. His commitment to genuineness in his readings demonstrates how Brown expects Black life to be portrayed and shared with one's whole being. Therefore, Brown's attempt to condense his much larger narrative into a shorter, potentially more accessible format may indicate his desire to encourage others to do the same. He aims to build up the Black playwriting community, not beat them down. He does this by example in his recording for The Library of Congress and through frustrated and urgent critiques in "Drama." Brown may not believe that poor representation of Black drama is caused entirely by a lack of ability among playwrights. However, his emphasis on the need for technical improvement rather than on the audience's internalized expectations of Black people in drama denotes an effort to bring Black writers forward in the dramatic industry.

Brown's description of the "Modern Period" is a further indication of the unfortunate state of the reception of Black drama. While Brown notes an overall improvement in messaging in a creative sense, praising the (slow) incorporation of Black folklife into the theatre, he displays hints of disappointment in the community for their continued shortcoming in storytelling ability. Having published numerous critical reviews, Brown has direct contact with the intentions behind the drama, is in touch with the current theatrical scene, and has some authority in defining what "good" drama looks like. Brown praises playwrights such as Ridgely Torrence, who "showed the dramatic possibilities of the folk element" in The *Rider of Dreams, Simon the Cyrenian*, and Granny Maumee (Brown 8). His positive feedback focuses on Black creative (not storytelling) ability, and he notes that after Torrence's plays, many playwrights followed his lead. However, he reverts to his initial assertion that plays were too heavily centered on social statements and that they fail to effectively and authentically convey the realities of Black life. His focus shifts to the broader dramatic scene as he considers how Black characters were used by white writers who had no connection to Black folk life. Many white writers used Black characters as "a symbol of social protest," indicating that there has been a healthy social change in the perception of Black people, especially in an artistic sense:

> James Knox Millen's *Never No More* (1932), Frederick Schlick's *Bloodstream* (1932), John Wexley's *They Shall Not Die* (1934), and Paul Peters and George Sklar's *Stevedore* (1934) all protest the injustice which is the Negro daily lot in America. This trend, though a reversion to the problem drama, is exceedingly healthy because it takes the Negro out of any narrow racial groove and puts him in the full stream of the proletarian movement. These plays make the Negro character

the oppressed of the earth. (Brown 9)

Although he praises the newly found representation of folklife in the theatre, Brown suggests that plays have a long way to go, technically speaking, in delivery and writing. While these contributions to drama heightened the impact of the "Negro Renaissance," he recommended that a "School of New Negro dramatists" should be established," indicating his sentiment of continued inadequacy in the Black playwright community (Brown 9). He continues to emphasize that while many plays contain "much good raw material," which they fail to use effectively, playwrights both Black and white fail to successfully unveil the richness of Black life (Brown 10). Frequently, plays of important premises would make their way into mainstream media only to be overshadowed by the rest of the dramatic scene after a short time. Brown shows frustration with Black theatre with the realization that even when a play "showed the most brilliant promise of any Negro vehicle to appear on Broadway, [...] the promise [would] not [be] fulfilled by a subsequent work" (Brown 10). Brown's dismay comes from an apparent belief that the beauty in Black folklife speaks for itself. His grievances with the dramatic industry concerning Black representation come from his perceived inauthenticity in writing. Since these plays tended to be social rather than artistic projects, only appealing to white audiences, they lacked the honesty and emotion required to convey to an audience that Black life is essential in a social justice context. His lament to the industry suggests that Brown's role as a social activist is best characterized by his commitment to portraying Black life with genuineness and passion and his encouragement for others to follow suit.

Unlike in "Drama," Brown does not discuss the history of Black characters in the format of a clear chronology in *Negro Poetry and Drama*. Instead, he emphasizes plays that accurately portray Black life, exhibiting that creativity exists in the Black community to portray Black life. While he critiques the narrative quality of the plays, he does not resort to the shortcomings in the skill of Black playwrights as harshly. Instead, he takes on a more constructive yet hopeful tone: "None of the Negro folk playwrights show the structural skill of white dramatists like Marc Connelly, or the power and scope of Paul Green. This is to be expected since they are still learning" (Brown 122). His softer tone highlights that because there has been such a lack of representation in the arts, there has simply not been enough time for Black artists to develop the same skills and draw from the same vein of artistic history as white writers. He also attributes undeveloped skills to a lack of effort to educate Black playwrights in universities and other institutions. While Brown conducts his analysis of Black characters starting from the perspective of writers, beginning in a similar manner to "Drama," he later moves on to the audience's contributions to the acceptance of Black artists in the industry. Firstly, Brown notes that most "serious" theatre that included Black characters was "produced by whites for whites" and "soon lost its rudimentary realism: the dialect became gibberish and caricature a cartoon" (Brown 106). However, his hopefulness persists throughout the book as he highlights that the rise of Black companies and theatre education greatly "enriched the lives of countless students and mentored several generations of scholars" (Brown 1). Brown notes that this rise in education for Black playwrights is a first step in catalyzing the abilities and stories of Black life. One play Brown praises is *The Green Pastures*, written in 1930 by Marc Connelly. Connelly's play, based on a book of fictionalized "folk stories" by Roark Bradford, a southern-white writer, was also praised as a simple, yet glorified representation of Black folk life: "Newspaper files reveal that audiences of the 1930s were so affected by the 'simple folk charm' of this glorified pageant that it ran for eighteen solid months in New York, then toured the south and Canada" (Harold 41). Since Connelly was a white playwright, Brown, nor other play critics, do not discuss any technical deficiency in his writing in reviews of *The Green Pastures*. Instead, Brown focuses on its tribute to Black folk life: "If the play is not accurate truth about the religion of the folk-Negro, it is movingly true to folk life" (Brown 119). This play was highly regarded in the theatre community due to Connelly's preexisting status as a "good" playwright, predisposing him to success. Connelly had an existing audience to present his work to, unlike most Black playwrights. Connelly's pre-established following was vital to the play's success and accessibility to a large audience. Brown, a renowned Black play critic, could watch and review the play. However, one must consider who *The Green Pastures* was written for and who ended up in the audience. An article in Volume 42 of the *Negro History Bulletin* by Walter C. Daniel describes the discriminatory environment where *The Green Pastures* showed, illustrating that Brown, as a renowned Black critic, was an anomalous witness to the alleged accurate portrayal of Black life: "The management announced that the National Theatre had not changed its racial policy and that Negroes would not be permitted to enter the theatre" (Daniel 42). Despite Brown's high praise for the accuracy in the portrayal of Black life, he was an exception to the accessibility barrier. This is further demonstrated by the fact that during the time *Green Pastures* was running "Negroes did not support the play in any noticeable numbers" (Harold 41). Brown, therefore, is slightly biased in his perception of the impact of the play. Because it was not widely accessible to a Black audience, no one else could vouch for its truthful portrayal. Brown himself notes that

"if the play is not accurate truth about the religion of the folk-Negro, it is movingly true to folk life," which indicates that the play was only accurate to some aspects of Black life (Brown 119). Brown presents minor criticisms of *The Green Pastures* yet maintains that it is a moving portrayal of Black life. This follows its white audiences, who also saw it as a profound insight into Black folk life. However, without a Black audience or the perspective of a Black author, it is evident that despite being praised for its "holistic" portrayal, aspects of Black life were still overlooked.

Despite a seemingly grim attitude toward the efforts of Black playwrights, at the end of "Drama," Brown affirms that there is hope for their future in the slowly growing field. He claims that in the "Modern Era…individual actors like Robeson, Ingram, and others, have been given unusual (i.e., for America) opportunities on the national stage," even mentioning that "treatment by white writers has grown tremendously in depth, sympathy, and understanding" (Brown 13). White audiences, as noted in his book *Negro Poetry and Drama,* frequently have rejected plays and art by Black playwrights and artists because of preconceived expectations of Black character roles. However, because there has been "precious little" drama produced by Black playwrights, Brown stands in a unique position to elevate and inspire Black dramatists (Brown 2). As a figure of relative authority in the dramatic industry as a critic, Brown wields some power in defining good drama. He demonstrates his authority in his literature on drama, including numerous articles published in *Opportunity: Journal for Negro Life* magazine, his book, *Negro Poetry and Drama*, and in his unpublished manuscript, "Drama." His contributions to the dramatic industry foregrounded Black artists on more accessible platforms, spreading his message to wider audiences beyond the world of theatre. However, his criticism also served to encourage consistent growth in Black playwriting. Archival materials, such as drafts, allow us to track not only Brown's thinking about the evolution of drama but also the state of the theatre from a social justice perspective. Through his tonality and urgency, we see his disappointment in the theatre and Black playwrights since the publication of *Negro Poetry and Drama*. However, he does not lose hope. Rather, he encourages the Black playwright with a heavier hand. Brown's continued analysis of the role of Black people in drama is a tribute to Brown's scholarly approach, which he would continue throughout his career. It was once Brown did reach the end of his career and his archive was acquired by Howard University, his place of employment from 1929 to 1969, and organized by Williams College in 2018, that his narrative opinions and throughlines can be pieced together. While manuscripts like "Drama" demarcate the numerous, tumultuous, and changing opinions toward Black drama, his choice to publish *Negro Poetry and Drama* shows his overall dedication to encouragement and hope and a resistance to the dominant narrative about Black theater.

Conclusion: Brown's Pedagogy

So, what does Brown think is absent from the Black dramatic narrative? Brown's archived work, published literature, and public-facing content suggest that authenticity and emotion are the missing ingredients to portraying Black life to its fullest capacity. Until the time of the writing of "Drama," Brown seems to notice that "vast areas of Negro experience and character remain unexplored" (Brown 138). Because Black characters had been reduced to predictability, single dimensionality, and stereotypes, there had been no exploration of the vitality and richness of Black life. Genuine performance and authenticity are Brown's solutions. While he knows that education and improved leadership can remedy the technical abilities of Black playwrights, Brown demonstrates in his work and performances that the way to an audience's heart is through emotion and realism. As the situation becomes more pressing, it becomes clear that Brown is increasingly frustrated with Black writers, urging them to break free of centuries of expectation and stereotype. As Brown writes in *Negro Poetry and Drama*, "the treatment of the Negro character with honest realism certainly does not seem too much to ask" (Brown 137).

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